

Institution letterhead

Study information for ME/CFS patients

Request to participate in medical research:

University of Geneva, Institute of Global Health, Faculty of Medicine

Title of the research project

Healthcare needs and service provision for Myalgic Encephalomyelitis/Chronic Fatigue Syndrome (ME/CFS) in Switzerland: national surveys of patients

Lay title: How do people with ME/CFS experience healthcare in Switzerland?

Short summary

Dear Madam, Dear Sir,

We are asking whether you would be willing to take part in our research project.

Your participation is voluntary. All data collected in this research project are subject to strict data protection rules.

The research project is conducted by the project lead at the University of Geneva. If you are interested, we will be happy to inform you about the results of this research project.

This document explains the most important points. To give you an initial overview, the most important information is provided first. More detailed information follows afterwards.

Why are we conducting this research project?

ME/CFS is a severe, chronic disease. Many affected people report severe exhaustion, worsening after exertion, concentration problems, and major limitations in everyday life.

In Switzerland, we still know too little about what care people with ME/CFS receive, what support is missing, and what experiences patients have with the healthcare system. With this research project, we would like to better understand this situation.

What do I have to do if I participate? What happens to me if I participate?

Form of participation: If you decide to take part, you will complete an online questionnaire. There will be no blood sampling, no medical examinations, no genetic examinations, and no treatment as part of this research project.

Course of participation: First, you read this study information. Then you confirm online that you would like to participate. After that, you answer the online questionnaire. Completing it is expected to take about 20 to 40 minutes. You may skip individual questions.

What benefits and risks are associated with participation?

Benefits

You will probably not have any direct personal benefit from taking part in this research project. However, your answers can help to better understand and, in the long term, improve care for people with ME/CFS in Switzerland.

Risks and burden

The risks are low. Completing the questionnaire may take time and energy. Some questions may be burdensome because they relate to illness experiences or care experiences. You may skip questions or stop participating before submitting the questionnaire.

By actively confirming online at the beginning of the questionnaire, you confirm that you participate voluntarily and that you have understood the contents of this document.

Detailed information

1. Aim and selection

We refer to our research undertaking in this information sheet as a research project. If you participate in this research project, you are a participant.

In this research project, we want to investigate the needs, experiences, and care situations of people with Myalgic Encephalomyelitis/Chronic Fatigue Syndrome, abbreviated ME/CFS, in Switzerland. In addition, healthcare professionals will be asked about their experiences with ME/CFS care. This study information is addressed to patients.

We are asking you because you may participate if you:

- are 18 years old or older;
- live in Switzerland;
- self-report that you have ME/CFS, or have received a medical diagnosis of ME/CFS;
- can understand the study information and give consent;
- can complete the questionnaire in German, French, Italian, or English.

You cannot participate if you do not live in Switzerland or cannot give consent.

2. General information

This section briefly summarises the most important points.

We still know little about how people with ME/CFS in Switzerland gain access to diagnosis, treatment, rehabilitation, and support. We would therefore like to find out where care works well and where gaps exist.

If you participate, you will answer an online questionnaire once. The research project is coordinated by the University of Geneva and conducted throughout Switzerland. It is a non-interventional research project according to Chapter 2 of the Human Research Ordinance (HRO), Category A with minimal risk.

The research project is expected to last about 36 months in total. Recruitment and data collection are planned for about 18 months. The data will then be cleaned, analysed, and reported.

We conduct this research project as required by Swiss law. We also comply with all internationally recognised guidelines. The competent ethics committee reviews the research project as part of the submission procedure.

3. Procedure

Here we describe the practical procedure. There are only project-related procedures connected with the online questionnaire. There are no visits, no medical examinations, and no sample collections.

1. You receive the link to the online questionnaire, for example through a patient organisation, a website, a newsletter, or another public announcement.
2. You read the study information.
3. You confirm that you meet the inclusion criteria.
4. You give your online consent if you would like to participate.
5. You complete the online questionnaire on KoboToolbox.
6. At the end, you may voluntarily indicate whether we may contact you for possible future studies.
7. The research group separates voluntarily provided contact details from the questionnaire responses before analysis.
8. The analysis is carried out using de-identified data.

The questionnaire contains closed questions and optional free-text fields. The questions concern, among other topics, ME/CFS, diagnostic pathways, access to healthcare, barriers to care, support services, and unmet needs.

It may be necessary to exclude you from the research project early. This may happen if you do not meet the inclusion criteria or do not confirm the mandatory online consent.

4. Benefits

You will probably not have any direct personal benefit from participating.

If you take part in this research project, your answers can help make care gaps and needs of people with ME/CFS in Switzerland visible. The results may be important for other people with the same disease, as well as for healthcare professionals, research, and health planning.

5. Voluntary participation and obligations

You participate voluntarily. If you do not take part in this research project or later wish to withdraw your participation, you do not have to give a reason. Your treatment/care is guaranteed independently of your decision.

If you participate in this research project, you will be asked to:

- read the study information;
- confirm the online consent only if you would like to participate;
- answer the questions to the best of your knowledge;
- not enter names of other persons, exact addresses, or unnecessary identifying details in free-text fields.

You may skip individual questions. You may stop participating before submission at any time by closing the browser.

6. Risks and burden

Through the research project, you are exposed only to minor risks. There are no physical risks from examinations or treatments because no such measures take place.

Possible burdens are:

- time required of about 20 to 40 minutes;
- fatigue or concentration burden when completing the questionnaire;
- possible emotional burden from questions about illness experiences or care experiences;
- a low data protection risk, as with any internet-based data collection.

We reduce these risks by allowing you to skip questions, pause the questionnaire, not use direct identifying data for the analysis, and check and de-identify free-text responses before analysis.

7. Alternatives

If you do not want to participate in this research project, you will not experience any disadvantages. There is no treatment or care that you receive only by participating in this research project.

8. Results

There are no individual medical results in this research project that directly concern you. No diagnostic examinations, genetic examinations, or imaging procedures are carried out. Incidental findings are therefore not expected.

The objective final results of the entire research project may be published in scientific journals, reports, presentations, or other scientific and public health formats.

Publication will take place only in summarised or anonymised form. Individual participants should not be identifiable. If you are interested, we can send you a summary of the overall results at the end of the research project.

9. Confidentiality of data and samples

No biological samples are collected or stored in this research project. This chapter therefore concerns the confidentiality and protection of your data.

9.1 Data processing and de-identification

For this research project, data about you and your health are collected and processed, partly in automated form. This may include health-related information about ME/CFS, care experiences, support, disease duration, severity, and general demographic information.

The main questionnaire dataset will be de-identified. This means: We avoid direct identifying data such as name, address, telephone number, exact date of birth, insurance numbers, or medical record numbers. Age information, geographic information, and other demographic information are collected as broadly as possible, for example as age groups or regions.

Free-text responses will be checked before analysis. Information that could possibly make a person identifiable will be removed or generalised. This includes, for example, names, very precise locations, employers, institutions, or other distinctive individual details.

9.2 Data protection and protection of data

All data protection requirements are strictly observed. Data collection takes place through KoboToolbox. KoboToolbox is used as an online platform for data collection. KoboToolbox is not used as a certified platform for qualified electronic signatures.

At the beginning of the questionnaire, you will see a mandatory consent page. You can start the questionnaire only if you actively confirm that you have read and understood the study information and would like to participate in the study. No handwritten signature and no qualified electronic signature will be collected.

Online consent is documented by your active confirmation on the consent page. If technically available, the system additionally stores that the consent page was completed before the start of the questionnaire.

Only authorised members of the research team have access to the data. The data are stored securely and with restricted access.

9.3 Data protection in possible further use and future contact

At the end of the questionnaire, we ask patients whether they would like to be contacted for possible future studies. This is voluntary. You can participate in the current study without providing contact details.

If you agree to later contact, you may provide your first name, last name, and email address. This information will be used only for possible later contact.

We also ask you separately whether selected data from this questionnaire may be reused in possible future studies. This can help avoid duplicate entries and reduce your burden in later studies. This consent is also voluntary and independent of participation in this research project.

Each additional future study will be submitted separately to the competent ethics committee, if required. Separate consent will be obtained for a future study.

9.4 Confidentiality risks in internet-based research

For technical and practical reasons, the online consent, questionnaire responses, and voluntarily provided contact details may initially be collected within the same KoboToolbox submission.

If you provide contact details, the dataset is not considered anonymous at the time of collection. The data are then treated as temporarily identifiable or linkable data until separation and de-identification have been completed.

Before analysis, the contact details are separated from the questionnaire responses. The contact details are stored in a separate file with restricted access. Analysis is carried out using a de-identified dataset without names and email addresses.

A small residual risk of indirect re-identification can never be completely excluded with health data. This risk may arise if several indirect details are combined, for example age group, gender, region, disease duration, severity, and care pathway. We reduce this risk through broad categories, de-identification of free-text responses, restricted data access, secure storage, and aggregated reporting. Small subgroups will not be reported separately if this creates a risk of re-identification.

9.5 Inspection rights in audits

This research project may be reviewed by the competent ethics committee and by the project lead. Persons carrying out such reviews may access project-related documents for this purpose. Everyone must maintain absolute confidentiality.

10. Withdrawal

You may withdraw from the research project at any time.

Before submitting the questionnaire, you can stop participating by closing the browser. In this case, your answers will not be included in the analysis, insofar as they have not been transmitted.

After submitting the questionnaire, deletion of your questionnaire responses may no longer be possible if the responses have already been de-identified and can no longer be reliably assigned to a specific person.

If you voluntarily provided contact details, you may withdraw your consent to being contacted again at any time. In this case, your contact details will be deleted, unless there is a legal or ethical obligation to retain them.

11. Compensation

If you participate in this research project, you will not receive compensation. Participation will not result in any costs for you or your health insurance.

12. Liability

The research project is non-interventional and involves minimal risk. No medical interventions, examinations, or treatments are carried out. Therefore, no additional study insurance is planned.

If you have questions about harm or complaints related to the research project, please contact the contact persons listed below.

13. Funding

This research project is conducted as an academic research project at the University of Geneva. There is no commercial sponsor. The project participants declare no financial or personal conflicts of interest that could influence the research project.

14. Contact person(s)

You may ask questions about participation in the project at any time. Also in case of uncertainties during or after the research project, please contact:

Prof. Olivia Keiser

Institute of Global Health, Faculty of Medicine, University of Geneva

Chemin des Mines 9, 1202 Geneva, Switzerland

Email: olivia.keiser@unige.ch

Yuying Gao

PhD candidate, Institute of Global Health, Faculty of Medicine, University of Geneva

Email: yuying.gao@etu.unige.ch

Ethics committee / BASEC number: 2026-00834

Declaration of consent

Online declaration of consent to participate in a research project

Please read this form carefully. Please ask if you do not understand something or would like to know more. Your consent is necessary for participation.

Because this research project is conducted entirely online, consent is given through active confirmation on the consent page of the online questionnaire. No handwritten signature and no qualified electronic signature will be collected.

BASEC number (after submission):	2026-00834
Title of the research project (scientific and lay language):	Healthcare needs and service provision for Myalgic Encephalomyelitis/Chronic Fatigue Syndrome (ME/CFS) in Switzerland: national surveys of patients and

	healthcare providers / How do people with ME/CFS experience healthcare in Switzerland?
Responsible institution (project lead with address):	University of Geneva, Institute of Global Health, Faculty of Medicine, Chemin des Mines 9, 1202 Geneva, Switzerland
Place of conduct:	Online, throughout Switzerland; coordinated by the University of Geneva
Project leader at the study site:	Prof. Olivia Keiser
Participant:	Online participation; name and date of birth are not collected for participation

- I have read and understood the study information.
- I participate in this research project voluntarily and accept the content of the written information.
- I had enough time to make my decision. I know whom I can contact if I have questions.
- I understand that this research project consists only of an online questionnaire and includes no medical examinations, treatments, or sample collections.
- I understand that I can skip individual questions.
- I understand that I can stop the questionnaire at any time before submitting it.
- I agree that my de-identified questionnaire data may be analysed scientifically.
- I agree that summarised and anonymised results may be published in scientific journals, reports, or presentations.
- I agree that the responsible specialists of the project lead and the ethics committee responsible for this research project may inspect project-related documents for audit and control purposes, while strictly maintaining confidentiality.
- I consent to participate in this research project.

Optional consents:

- I agree to be contacted for possible future studies, and I voluntarily provide my contact details for this purpose.
- I agree that selected data from this questionnaire may be reused in possible future ethically reviewed studies in order to avoid duplicate entries.

If you do not confirm the mandatory consent points, you cannot participate in the questionnaire. The optional points regarding recontact and possible reuse of selected data are not a prerequisite for participation in this study.